Voices from the Lowell Mills

Mary S. Paul, a Lowell mill worker · December 21, 1845

Source: Letter of Mary Paul to her father (1845), Paul family papers, Vermont Historical Society. Public domain. Complete letter.

> A fifteen-year-old Vermont farm girl who went to work in the Lowell textile mills describes the dangers, long hours, wages, and rhythms of factory life in her own words.

COMPLETE TEXT — UNEDITED

Lowell Dec. 21st 1845. Dear Father: I received your letter on Thursday the 14th with much pleasure. I am well which is one comfort. My life and health are spared while others are cut off. Last Thursday one girl fell down and broke her neck which caused instant death. She was going in or coming out of the mill and slipped down it being very icy. The same day a man was killed by the cars. Another had nearly all of his ribs broken. Another was nearly killed by falling down and having a bale of cotton fall on him.

Last Tuesday we were paid. In all I had six dollars and sixty cents paid $4.68 for board. With the rest I got me a pair of rubbers and a pair of 50 cts shoes. Next payment I am to have a dollar a week beside my board. We have not had much snow the deepest being not more than 4 inches. It has been very warm for winter.

Perhaps you would like something about our regulations about going in and coming out of the mill. At 5 o'clock in the morning the bell rings for the folks to get up and get breakfast. At half past six it rings for the girls to get up and at seven they are called to the mill. At half past 12 we have dinner are called back again at one and stay till half past seven.

I get along very well with my work. I can doff as fast as any girl in our room. I think I shall have frames before long. The usual time allowed for learning is six months but I think I shall have frames before I have been in three as I get along so fast. I think that the factory is the best place for me and if any girl wants employment I advise them to come to Lowell.

Tell Harriet that though she does not hear from me she is not forgotten. I have little time to devote to writing that I cannot write all I want to. Tell Harriet I send my love to her and all of the girls. Give my love to Mrs. Clement. Tell Henry this will answer for him and you too for this time. This from Mary S. Paul.